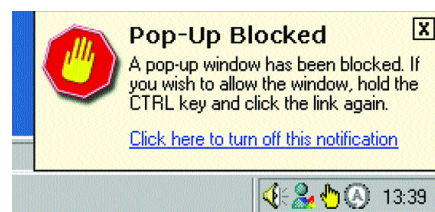


enter your e-mail address, is increasingly becoming the method of choice for offering these. Sites conducting surveys to improve their consumer service, also ask for participation through pop-ups. Some sites place a cookie on your system so they don't show you the same pop-up again.

Another reason to make the switch

A very simple solution to the pop-up problem is to use a browser with in-built pop-up protection. There is a certain level of pop-up protection in all the new versions of popular browsers such as Opera and Mozilla. Mozilla Firebird, a free browser, is very easy to use because it functions a lot like Internet Explorer. It blocks pop-ups silently—only giving a warning the first time they're blocked—with an exclamation mark in the status bar indicating that a pop-up is blocked.



When pop-ups are blocked the notification is easy to see. It also tells you how to temporarily disable blocking

Firebird works quite effectively and is sufficient for most users who don't want the hassles of configuring other software. To enable, or disable pop-up blocking, go to **Tools > Options** and select Web Features from the left pane. There will be a 'Block Popup Windows' checkbox on the right. Below the check box, you can enter the URLs of the sites you do not want pop-ups blocked from. This is commonly called a safe list, and is an easy way to let the software know from which trusted sites you do not want pop-ups blocked. There are no other advanced controls and settings, but most pop-ups are taken care of quite effectively at this stage. For greater protection, you'll need a dedicated utility.

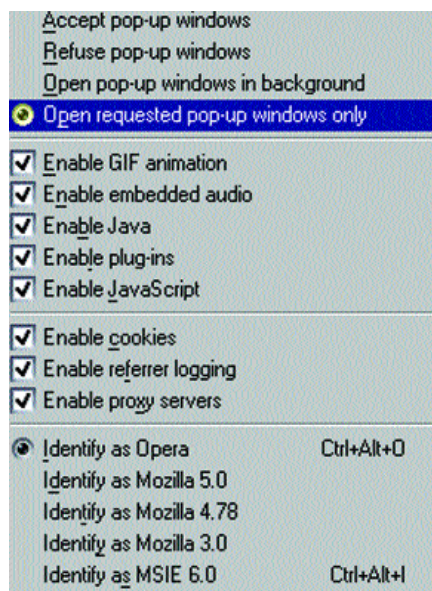
PopUp Stopper Professional is a comprehensive pop-up blocker that works with most browsers. It blocks pop-ups that got past Firebird's defences. The program has some great features. It plays a sound, brings up an indicator over the system tray and changes the mouse cursor to a bright red blocked signal when a pop-up is blocked—so you just can't miss it. Other privacy features include clean-

Pop-Ups put to Good Use

Marketers put pop-ups to several uses. Newsletter and e-mail list subscriptions can be solicited using pop-ups across all the pages of your Web site. A cookie would ensure that the user sees the pop-up only once, no matter which page of your site he visits first. Pop-ups informing users of special discounts, or offers on the items that they are currently reading about would be welcomed. Polls and quick questions get a good response when offered through pop-ups. The key here is keeping the user interested by presenting it in the right way and asking the right questions to get the info you need to improve his experience. The more you know about your customers, the better you can mould your site or business to their needs and maximise revenue. A pop-up when the user leaves your site—called an Exit Pop-up—can be used to obtain the user's e-mail address, thank them for visiting the Web site, or offer to add your Web site to their Favorites list so they can easily find their way back. One of the coolest uses of pop-ups is to offer direct help for the meaning of certain words on the page. Clicking the word shows a pop-up with a short meaning and a link to the related info.

Marketers can effectively use pop-ups by observing some simple guidelines and keeping in mind two simple things—relevance and usability. If the contents of the pop-up are useless, no amount of glitter and sparkle will make a surfer interested. So content creators must understand the type of user visiting their site, and create content relevant to them.

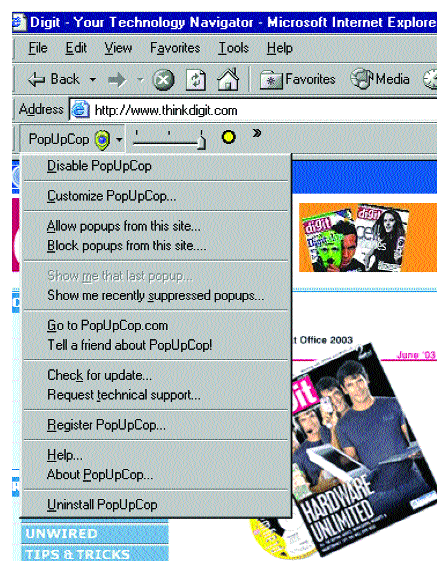
Designers can increase usability by keeping the design simple and easy to navigate. Smaller HTML code and smaller size of graphics will reduce loading time, which greatly increases the chances of your message being seen. Having more than one pop-up open at the same time is a definite no-no. That defeats the purpose of attracting attention to an important message, and ensures your visitor will lose interest quickly.



Opera's Quick Preferences allow you to quickly adjust settings including pop-up blocking and filtering of other content

ing of your browser's cache, erasing browser and Windows histories, even emptying your recycle bin and clearing the Windows clipboard. If you need the extra protection, go ahead and install it.

Opera affords a little more control to deal with pop-ups. It also offers effective blocking built right into the browser. To turn on pop-up blocking, simply press



PopUpCop's main menu button gives access to most of the program's basic options

[F12] to bring up the quick preferences menu; here, you will find four options—accept pop-ups, Refuse pop-ups, Open pop-up windows in the background and Open only requested pop-up windows.

The last option—open only requested pop-ups—works best most of the time. As always, through trial and error, you should look to find your own balance between cleaner surfing and the possibility of useful pop-ups being blocked.